VOC's conviction. He must have realized the need for committed hands to steady the ship. On a family visit to Chittoor, Venkatarama Aiyar used the opportunity to tour all over North Arcot district for a month, focusing on selling shares in Wallajanagar and Ranipet.[92] However, his tour of Thanjavur district, the CID reported with barely concealed glee, was a disaster; not only did no one show interest, 'some went to the extent of laughing at and ridiculing the idea'.[93]

The other patriot to give himself fully to the company was S.D. Krishna Aiyangar. If little is known about K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar, we know barely more about Krishna Aiyangar. Since he had begun his legal practice in 1898, he may have been a few years younger to VOC. Further, he had joined SSNCo due to his political commitment. This is the sum total of our knowledge of a man who worked so selflessly for a noble cause.[94] In the two years or so following the imprisonment of VOC, Krishna Aiyangar, though continuing to be designated as 'honorary secretary' of SSNCo, was very much its public face. Learning on the job, he was 'attending to everything personally'.[95] He managed the day-to-day affairs of the company, raised money, shuttled between Tuticorin and Colombo, and travelled to Madras, Bombay and Calcutta to shore up the company. All public statements of SSNCo appeared in his name. In 1924, it was Krishna Aiyangar who gave evidence to the Indian Mercantile Marine Committee as a representative of indigenous entrepreneurship: more than ten years after the company's collapse, the wounds were so raw that he had to withdraw parts of his angry statement to the committee (see Chapter 11). Despite his onerous duties as the secretary, he led the fundraising efforts as well. In June, accompanied by three pleaders from Sattur, Krishna Aiyangar went to nearby Elayirampannai, in Tirunelveli district, to convince some local merchants to take shares; '(t)hey came to no settlement with these merchants and left the place the next day.'[96] He was not disheartened by this failure but proceeded to Tiruchirappalli on the same chore.[97]

We noted that S. Somasundara Bharati had resigned from the company in November 1907. But during the hectic months between January and March